The newsletter playbook (prompt 54 §2), 2 Nov 2026

What the people who built the best newsletters and premium media have said in public, applied to one premium letter about Portugal (D74).

The notes, every figure and every source are in:

- sponsors/research/playbook_group1.md: Morning Brew, Axios, The Hustle, beehiiv, Lenny, plus Milk Road, TLDR, Van Trump and Chartr;
- sponsors/research/playbook_group2.md: Not Boring, Puck, The Real Deal, Shanken, Monocle, Hodinkee, Mansion Global, Robb Report, HTSI;
- sponsors/research/playbook_group3.md: Oshinsky, McGarry, SparkLoop, Paved, Passionfroot, Who Sponsors Stuff, beehiiv data.

All sources were read on 2 Nov 2026. "S" marks a secondary source (press citing the company) and "D" our own arithmetic on cited figures. Podcast minute marks come from machine transcripts (±30 s). Quotes are under 15 words.

0. Who we read, and the ideas that matter for us

Who	Ideas that matter for us	Main sources
Morning Brew (Lieberman, Rief)	Ads written in the letter's voice by in-house copywriters, then approved by the client. Priced per thousand **opens**, $60–70 in 2019. 90% of H1 2019 sold by February; renewals above 70%. Referrals before paid growth. "The more niche, the better."	Digiday 9 May 2019 and 5 Aug 2020; My First Million, 4 Apr 2025 [14:37, 21:25, 32:37, 55:59]
Axios (VandeHei, Allen, Schwartz)	One short native unit, "A message from…": no banners, no programmatic. Newsletter sponsorships sold as **one-week exclusives**, with higher prices in weeks that matter. Brevity as the product. Pro tier: $599/yr, about $2M in year one.	Digiday 10 and 25 Jan 2017, 20 Jan 2023; Built In 9 Aug 2022 (S)
The Hustle (Parr)	He sold the first ads himself ($4,600, 2016), then hired salespeople. Content people share before paid ads. A $300/yr product paid up front. Sold to a buyer who wanted the audience.	MFM 2025 [15:31, 37:20]; TechCrunch 4 Feb 2021
beehiiv (Denk)	Paid recommendations, priced per subscriber (example $2.50). An ad network for small lists. Referral rewards should be cheap to fulfil and worth one share. Independents do sales and writing themselves.	product.beehiiv.com 27 Apr 2023 and 5 Feb 2024; Latka 24 Jun 2024
Lenny's Newsletter	He said no to newsletter ads and sold that demand to the podcast. Paid tier at "more than Netflix" with extra value. Partners pay readers in kind (Product Pass), not per slot. "A lot of saying no." Cut frequency without losing readers.	First Round Review 15 Apr 2026; lennysnewsletter.com/productpass
Not Boring (McCormick)	Two products: a top slot, and a **sponsored deep dive** at about 4–7× its price ($20k vs $3–5k in 2021, S). A published selection test; under a third of requests accepted. The sponsor as a way into a bigger subject. Sold by publishing the deck.	notboring.co 5 Apr 2021; selection doc; The Rebooting 2021 (S)
Puck (Kelly)	"In a world of too much, scarcity matters." Tiers and access: dinners for a $250 tier. Ads became the bigger line. About $75M → $250M valuation by staying premium.	The Rebooting 5 Sep 2023; TheWrap 26 Aug 2026
The Real Deal (Korangy)	Independence is the pitch: developers ask to pull stories. Events moderated by its editors, never pay-to-play. A yearly Data Book with 80+ rankings. Newsletter ad CTR 0.22%: it sells authority, not clicks.	TRD publisher's note Mar 2010; TRD media kit Q4 2023
Wine Spectator / Cigar Aficionado (Shanken, died 29 Oct 2026)	"Not 'a promotional arm'" (1983), and a "not recommended" rating that advertisers disliked. Blind method, published. Licensing a score for commercial use: $1,000/yr per brand. Pay-to-enter awards produced the 2008 fake-restaurant award. "We're in the education business."	winespectator.com obituary 29 Oct 2026; Shanken Ratings Network page; hoaxes.org (S)
Monocle (Brûlé)	Many small premium lines: advertorial, events, retail, café. In 2025, events grew 87%, and inward-investment, tourism and **real-estate** clients drove ad growth. Lisbon Quality of Life Conference: about 200 seats at $2,600. Paid features had only a light label ("X").	Winkontent Ltd accounts FY2025 (Companies House 05265119); monocle.com shop; Press Gazette 3 Mar 2017

Who	Ideas that matter for us	Main sources
Hodinkee (Clymer)	Editorial creates demand; limited editions made with brands survived. Buying stock at the top ($46M, 2021) brought layoffs and a 2024 return to editorial. It was then sold to a retailer in its own field.	Digiday podcast 2017; JCK 24 Jul and 4 Oct 2024
Mansion Global / Robb Report	Journalism is the sales argument; listings pay alongside. 2025 rate card: custom article $25,000; one week owning the daily newsletter $3,680. Robb Report Germany: full page €22,200.	WSJ Residential RE Overview 2025; jalag.de media kit 2026
FT HTSI	Branded content capped at one or two brands per category and four or five campaigns live. Usefulness sells luxury: 87% of readers bought something they found there.	Digiday 2016; FIPP 1 Jun 2022
The operators (Oshinsky, McGarry, SparkLoop, Paved, Passionfroot, Who Sponsors Stuff)	Price on opens: $15–50 per 1,000 opens. Short units at about ¼ of a native ad. Meta cost per subscriber: $2 is world class, $4 is good. Paid recommendations cost $2–7 per subscriber, with SparkLoop taking 20% + about 3.5%. Paved's CPM ladder: $3–30 broad, $30–75 niche, $75+ premium. Prospect from who already sponsors similar letters.	inboxcollective.com; newsletteroperator.com/p/newsletter-benchmarks; help.sparkloop.app; paved.com/blog (all via search extracts, see group 3 notes)

1. What they agree on, and where they disagree

They agree on six things:

1. **Content quality sets the ad price.** Rief: weak content means $3,000 ads instead of $50,000 (MFM 2025 [21:25]). Lenny reads each letter about 50 times.
2. **One native format, written in the letter's voice and clearly labelled.** No banners in email (Axios, Morning Brew, Oshinsky, beehiiv's block ads).
3. **Niche, engaged audiences earn the highest prices** (Lieberman, TLDR, Van Trump, Paved's ladder).
4. **Referrals and cross-promotion come before paid acquisition** (Morning Brew's tiers, Milk Road's single-PDF reward, beehiiv recommendations, Lenny's word of mouth).
5. **Ad revenue is cyclical.** COVID took about 30% of Morning Brew's booked revenue within weeks. So book in advance, in multi-month packages.
6. **Buyers pay for audience and trust.** HubSpot bought The Hustle, Robinhood bought Chartr, and Watches of Switzerland bought Hodinkee: each bought a defined audience.

They disagree on six things; the side that fits us is in brackets:

- **Price unit.** Per open (Morning Brew), CPC (beehiiv) or flat time-boxed exclusives (Axios). **(Axios: flat, by week or month, exclusive by category. It is D6 by design.)**
- **Ad load.** About six paid elements a day at Morning Brew (2 Nov 2026 issue), one unit at Axios in 2017, none in Lenny's letter. **(Close to Axios: one sponsor element per letter, two at most.)**
- **Short native ads versus long sponsored pieces.** Not Boring, Monocle and Mansion Global sell whole features at 4–7× a slot. **(Both: the block as the base, a rare sponsored deep dive at the top.)**
- **Scale versus scarcity.** Morning Brew bought reach. Puck, Monocle and the Wine Experience sell a small, rich room. **(Scarcity: we will never have Morning Brew's scale, and our buyers are banks, resorts and developers.)**
- **Paid acquisition.** Brew spent $6–7M a year; Parr regretted his early ad spend; Lenny calls ads "worthless". **(No paid acquisition before revenue, hard rule 5. Recommendations and partner cross-promotion first.)**
- **Print and physical things.** Monocle, Wine Spectator, TRD and Robb Report keep print as the luxury signal. **(Not now. One printed object a year, the Portugal 100, once it pays for itself.)**

2. Quality guardrails

- **How many ads.**
  - Axios: one native unit, sold weekly. Morning Brew early on: one primary ad plus "a secondary ad some days" of about 80 words (Rief, A Media Operator, S). Lenny: none in the letter.
  - HTSI caps branded content at one or two brands per category and four or five campaigns live.
  - Oshinsky: readers leave dedicated sponsor sends much faster than the normal letter.
- **The ratio.** No one publishes a fixed ad-to-content ratio. In practice the sponsor element is 100–175 words in a letter of 800–1,500 (Axios ad about 175 words, 2017; Brew native copy 100–150 words).
- **Native done right.**
  - The letter's own writers draft the ad and the sponsor approves it (Morning Brew).

    - It sits in the same type, with a label that cannot be missed: "A message from" (Axios), "Presented by" and "Sponsored by" (Morning Brew), "Sponsored content" with copy and logo (TRD).
    - Monocle's "X" label was criticised as too light (Press Gazette 2017). Our label stays explicit (hard rule 4; Código da Publicidade art. 8).
- **What they refused, and why.**
    - Shanken refused to be "a promotional arm" and kept a "not recommended" band.
    - TRD keeps stories advertisers want pulled, and runs events without pay-to-play panels.
    - Packy accepts under a third of deep-dive requests, using a written test.
    - Lenny said no to newsletter ads altogether.
    - Axios refused banners and programmatic.
    - Kelly: Puck is as selective about advertisers as about stories.
- **The warning.** Pay-to-enter awards invite the 2008 Wine Spectator hoax. Any paid "badge" needs a check of the place or its documents, and published refusals.

3. Pricing at each size

Size	What they charged (reported)	Notes
About 1,000 subscribers	No benchmark supports a reach price here. First deals are brand bets: Morning Brew's first deal was about $3,000 for three placements with a watch brand (2016).	Sell as a founding partnership: price locked, the brand association, the report. Never a CPM (group 3, D).
5,000–20,000	Median main slot $300 for 5k–20k lists (Book a Sponsor, Oct 2026, S). Not Boring at about 10–40k: $3–5k per slot, $20k per deep dive (2021, S). Oshinsky floor "at least $500" at 10k (unverified).	$15–50 per 1,000 opens (Oshinsky); niche $30–75, premium/executive $75+ (Paved).
About 100,000 and more	Morning Brew at about 1M: $60–70 per 1,000 opens (2019). Milk Road at 250k: $3,000–4,000 per primary ad, $30–45 CPM (S). Mansion Global: $3,680 for a week of 100% share of voice in the daily (2025). TLDR: up to $30,000 per day (S).	Revenue per subscriber per year about $5–7 at Morning Brew, The Hustle and 1440 (D).

When to raise prices.

- Packy raised "in line with audience size" and charged more for Mondays.
- Axios charged more in the weeks that mattered.
- Morning Brew sold out the first half of the year by February, then moved up from direct-response to brand budgets.
- Milk Road was "fully sold out for months on end", which is the moment to raise.
- Our rule: raise every quarter in line with subscribers, and immediately when the next quarter is 80% booked. Hold a waiting list rather than add a second element.

Flat or CPM. Every premium title in group 2 sells flat units: weeks, takeovers, features, events. CPM is how the open market compares prices, so we publish our price per 1,000 subscribers once we pass 5,000. We never sell per click or per lead (D6).

4. Products beyond the ad slot

- **Title sponsorship.** Not Boring's "Presenting Sponsor" for a year (Ramp, 2025); Axios's weekly exclusive; Mansion Global's 100% share of voice.
- **Sponsored deep dive or custom feature.** Not Boring $20k vs $3–5k (S); Mansion Global $25,000 vs $3,680 a week. Our version is "A história, apresentada por", under Packy's rules.
- **Series.** A theme over several letters (golf weeks, Douro harvest) bought as a calendar, not as slots.
- **Events, small and editor-hosted.**
    - Monocle: about 200 seats at $2,600 (Lisbon 2026); events +87% in 2025.
    - Puck: dinners for its $250 tier.
    - TRD: 3,000+ at its forum, editors moderating.
    - Wine Experience: about $420 for one night, about $2,695 for the weekend (S).
- **Awards and rankings.** TRD's Data Book with 80+ rankings; Robb Report's "Best of the Best"; Wine Spectator's ratings and awards. Ours is the Portugal 100 (D69): one yearly reveal with one presenting sponsor, never paid entry.
- **Licensing a result.** Shanken charges $1,000/yr per brand to use a rating in its marketing. A later line for us, once the CEO and a lawyer agree; never paid entry into the ranking.
- **Commerce.** Hodinkee's limited editions worked; owning stock did not. Monocle's shops and café grew 22%, from "brand-in-residence" sponsorship. For us: products made with partners (a wine, a guide), never inventory.

- **Paid tiers.** Puck ($100/$250), Axios Pro ($599; about 2% of revenue in year one), The Hustle Trends ($300), Lenny ($200–400 with the Product Pass). For us: paid guides and calls (CLAUDE.md), and a paid tier only beyond 20,000 subscribers.
- **Jobs boards and classifieds.** About ¼ of a native ad (Oshinsky). Not for us: our classifieds would be property listings, which D9 and D14 exclude.
- **Paid recommendations.** beehiiv Boosts about $1.63–2.37 per subscriber; SparkLoop $2–7, with 20% + about 3.5% to the platform. Earning money by recommending other letters is a per-subscriber fee: a **CEO decision** under D6.
- **Data products.** The yearly Data Book (TRD), the Shanken Ratings Network database (425,000+ ratings). For us: the index and Portugal 100 as the asset, and the monthly sponsor report as the renewal tool (prompt 51).

5. Growth: what worked first

1. **Referrals with a reward that is cheap to fulfil.**
    - Morning Brew's tiers: 3 referrals unlocked a Sunday edition that could not be bought. More than 50,000 readers referred at least three.
    - Milk Road gave one PDF report for one referral.
2. **Cross-promotion and recommendations:** beehiiv Recommendations; swaps with similar letters; guest posts on established blogs (Lenny).
3. **Content people share.** The Hustle's blog brought 0.5–1M visitors a month.
4. **Paid acquisition, once retention is known.**
    - Reported costs per subscriber: McGarry rates $2 on Meta as world class and his own campaign cost $3.86; Milk Road paid $1.00–1.30 (S); TLDR pays $5–10 (S); beehiiv Boosts cost $1.63–2.37.
    - Payback works only if revenue per subscriber is high. Ours is high per head, but the list is small.
5. **For us:**
    - partner cross-promotion: the agency's mailing, the developers' lists, the diaspora chambers (prompt 48);
    - the Portugal 100 and the index as press hooks;
    - a referral reward: the Portugal 100 PDF before publication.

    Paid acquisition starts only after the first sponsor has paid (hard rule 5). Even then, under $3 a subscriber, with a three-month payback.

6. The sale: what made them sellable

Deal	Reported terms	What the buyer paid for
Axios → Cox, Aug 2022	$525M cash, about 5× the roughly $100M of 2022 revenue (S)	Profitable brand-funded newsletters; local expansion
Morning Brew → Insider/Axel Springer, Oct 2020	Majority stake at about $75M valuation; about 4× 2020 revenue of $20M, with $6M profit (MFM 2025; S)	Audience of young professionals, growth, a sales machine
The Hustle → HubSpot, Feb 2021	About $27M (Axios report, never confirmed); 1.5M subscribers, $12M revenue	SMB audience for software
Puck → RedBird (majority), Sep 2026	About $250M valuation, from about $75M three years earlier	Premium paid audience, insider voice, Air Mail bought for $16M
Hodinkee → Watches of Switzerland, Oct 2024	Undisclosed	Authority in its own field, editorial independence kept
Monocle minority stakes	Nikkei 2014 at about $115M; Sansiri 2017 at $47M	A brand with a rich audience, even while loss-making
Milk Road → Bitfo, Dec 2022	Undisclosed; 250k subscribers after 10 months	Search demand for the buyer's sites
Small newsletters (Flippa)	About 2.4× annual profit on average, H1 2025	Cash flow

What raised the multiple:

- documented sell-through and renewals (Morning Brew above 70%);
- a defined, rich audience;
- independence rules written down from day one (Wine Spectator, TRD);
- a strategic buyer in the field (HubSpot, Watches of Switzerland, Robinhood);
- a clean data room, so the sale does not hang on one offer (Rief's 11-month process).

For us: the buyer is a portal, an agency network or a media group (CLAUDE.md). Give them:

- 12 months of the monthly sponsor reports;
- renewal rates;
- subscribers by country and wealth signals;
- the index and its method;
- the editorial rules.

Could not verify

- Current rate cards for Morning Brew, Axios and Robb Report US.
- Lenny's sold-out calendar or waiting list.
- The Milk Road price.
- Oshinsky's "$500 at 10k" floor.
- Paved's category CPMs: the sources conflict ($7.11 per 1,000 subscribers vs about $85 CPM for finance).
- Any primary CPM for real-estate, luxury or travel newsletters.
- Big Smoke and official 2026 Wine Experience prices.
- Hodinkee revenue: WSJ via former employees, not the company.
- A Monocle sale in 2025: none found. The FY2025 UK accounts still name Brûlé as controlling party.
- Pages that blocked fetching were read through search extracts and are marked S: axios.com, puck.news, therealdeal.com, beehiiv.com, sparkloop.app, kit.com.
- Podcast minute marks only where a transcript existed.